

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ J 10 9 7
 ♥ K Q 10 6
 ♦ J 6
 ♣ J 5 4

♠ A 6 3
 ♥ A 9 2
 ♦ A 8 7
 ♣ A 9 7 6



♠ Q 5 4
 ♥ J 8 3
 ♦ Q 10 3
 ♣ K 10 8 2

♠ K 8 2
 ♥ 7 5 4
 ♦ K 9 5 4 2
 ♣ Q 3

West	North	East	South
Pass	1NT	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♣2.

Winner count: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 6

Wow. Things do look a little Acey/Spacey. If the ♦s are 3-2, which is likely, you can establish 2 tricks there. You need one more and the best hope is the ♣Q. There is a very good chance that East led from the ♣K. So with a brief prayer to Brigid (the Goddess of Bridge) you put up the ♣Q. It wins the trick.

Now you are on cruise-control. Play a ♦ to the ♦A. Play another ♦ back to dummy's ♦K (both defenders follow). Now a third ♦ sets up the rest of the suit.

As you can see your plan was the only way to make the contract.

Aces and Spaces is the description you often hear about this hand. But the REAL description is 16 points, balanced. So you open 1NT. Partner replies 2NT.

Partner is INVITING you to bid 3NT. If you have 17 points you should bid 3NT. If you have 15 points you should pass.

With 16 points you must make a judgement. This one is actually easy, despite the negative sound of "Aces and Spaces". In strength terms Aces are undervalued. Instead of being worth 4 points they are actually worth about 4.3 points. So you really do have a 17 point hand, and you bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♣2.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 8 5
 ♥ J 7 6 2
 ♦ 8 3
 ♣ A K Q 4 3

♠ J 9 6
 ♥ K Q 10 9
 ♦ K 5
 ♣ J 10 8 7



♠ A K 7 2
 ♥ A 8 3
 ♦ A Q 7 2
 ♣ 6 2

♠ Q 10 4 3
 ♥ 5 4
 ♦ J 10 9 6 4
 ♣ 9 5

West	North	East	South
2♣	Pass	1NT	Pass
3NT		2♠	Pass
All Pass			

3NT by East

Thanks to the opening lead you get an extra ♦ winner. Well, since the finesse would have worked it really isn't extra, it's just nice to know about it early. You need to find one more winner and the ♣ suit beckons. A 3-3 split would be very nice, but a 4-2 is more likely. Even with a 4-2 split you can still make your fifth ♣ good - but you must be careful with entries.

Since you have no immediate problem in any suit you can afford to give up the lead. So you play the ♣2 from your hand and the ♣3 from dummy. In other words, you duck a ♣. Somebody will win this trick cheaply and no doubt play another ♦. You don't mind at all - you win the ♦Q, the ♠A K, the ♥A and dummy's ♣A K Q 4, all of which are good.

Ducking the first ♣ is the only way to make the contract.

If you played a high ♣ first you would never have an entry back to dummy. You would have been forced to try to get there with the ♥J but as you can see, that wouldn't work.

If you had just played the ♣s from the top you would have made an overtrick when they split 3-3, but gone down when they split 4-2. Making an overtrick about 40% of the time is a high price to pay for going down the other 60%.

Despite the great ♣ suit, you have a 4-card Major. It is your duty to first seek an 8-card Major fit, so you bid 2♣ (Stayman). Partner replies 2♠.

Well, that wasn't the Major suit you were hoping for.

But with 11 points you have enough for game, so you bid 3NT.

West would play 3NT.

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East plays 3NT. South leads ♦J, North plays ♦K.

East plays 3NT. South leads ♦J, North plays ♦K.

Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 3 : Total = 8